

PROBLEM OF EVIL

VERSIONS AND BURDENS -> REPLY TYPOLOGY -> KINDS OF EVIL -> MACKIE AND THE BRIDGES -> PARADOX OF OMNIPOTENCE -> FREE-WILL DEFENCE -> AUGUSTINE -> SOUL-MAKING -> ROWE AND CORNEA -> HORRENDOUS AND ANIMAL EVIL -> PROCESS AND THE REPLY-SPACE -> INDIAN PARITY -> RELIGION-FOUNDING EVIL AND VERDICT

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis at Stage 12. Each card uses a layout chosen for its content; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE - Pending user review - repaired in place; all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

FOUR VERSIONS, FOUR BURDENS

LOGICAL — MACKIE 1955

EVIDENTIAL — ROWE 1979

EXISTENTIAL — ADAMS 1999

DISTRIBUTIONAL — KARMA

OMNIPOTENT + OMNISCIENT + GOOD + CREATOR

MISMATCH OF REPLY TO VERSION = ERROR

VERSION	CANONICAL PROPONENT	BURDEN ON THE THEIST	REPLY-TYPE THAT DISCHARGES IT
Logical	J. L. Mackie, Mind 1955	Show a possible morally sufficient reason	Defence — bare logical possibility suffices
Evidential	William Rowe 1979	Restore probability of divine permission	Theodicy, skeptical theism, or a revised God-concept
Existential	Marilyn McCord Adams 1999	Defeat the evil within the sufferer life	Goodness to persons, not global balancing
Distributional	Karma traditions, pan-Indian	Explain why this person suffers	Karma across lives; the West has no standard answer

WHAT EACH VERSION ALLEGES

- Logical: the theistic propositions form an inconsistent set
- Evidential: the amount and kinds of suffering make God improbable
- Existential: this life may not be a great good to the person living it
- Distributional: why this person rather than that one

WHAT EACH BURDEN DEMANDS

- Logical: exhibit a possible morally sufficient reason
- Evidential: restore probability, not mere consistency
- Existential: defeat the evil within the individual life
- Distributional: explain allocation, not permission

CONTROL POINTS

- Omniscience is not one of Mackie three propositions but blocks the reply that evil escaped divine notice
- Answering Rowe with Plantinga is a version error and loses marks

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Classify the version and its burden before selecting any defence, theodicy, revision or dissolution.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Name the version of the problem in the first two lines, because every theodicy is version-specific.

01

STAGE 01

DEFENCE, THEODICY, REVISION, DISSOLUTION

DEFENCE — GOD COULD HAVE A REASON

THEODICY — THIS IS THE REASON

REVISION — CHANGE THE GOD-CONCEPT

DISSOLUTION — REMOVE THE DEFENDANT

COST IS A MEASURE, NOT A REFUTATION

EXPLANATION IS NEVER PERMISSION TO WITHHOLD AID

DEFENCE — POSSIBILITY ONLY

- Plantinga free-will defence and Wykstra skeptical theism
- Success condition is bare logical possibility
- Refuted only by showing the proposed story is impossible

THEODICY — ACTUALITY CLAIMED

- Augustine privation, Hick soul-making, Leibniz best world, process theodicy
- Success condition is plausibility and truth
- Refuted if the proposed reason is false or insufficient

REVISION AND DISSOLUTION

- Process and finite God keep goodness and surrender omnipotence
- Advaita relocates evil to the empirical level
- Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa remove the creator entirely

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Match the reply-type to the burden, then price the reply by what it surrenders.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A defence says God could have a reason; a theodicy says what the reason actually is.

02

STAGE 02

KINDS OF EVIL AND THE SCOPE OF EACH REPLY

MORAL EVIL — MISUSED FREEDOM

NATURAL EVIL — LAW-GOVERNED NATURE

HORRENDOUS EVIL — ADAMS TECHNICAL SENSE

ANIMAL AND PRE-HUMAN SUFFERING

AMOUNT, KIND, DISTRIBUTION

LACTANTIUS, DE IRA DEI 13

MORAL EVIL — freely caused cruelty, betrayal, oppression; free-will defence, Augustine and soul-making all apply

NATURAL EVIL — earthquake, disease, congenital harm; free-will defence does not apply, soul-making does

HORRENDOUS EVIL — Adams technical sense; needs defeat within the individual life, not a global sum

ANIMAL AND PRE-HUMAN EVIL — no choice, no growth, no desert; only nomic regularity partly survives

SOURCE AND EXAMPLES

- Moral evil: cruelty, injustice, betrayal, oppression, war
- Natural evil: earthquake, disease, famine, congenital suffering
- Horrendous evil: participation gives prima facie reason to doubt the life is a great good to the participant
- Animal evil: predation and disease before any human moral agency

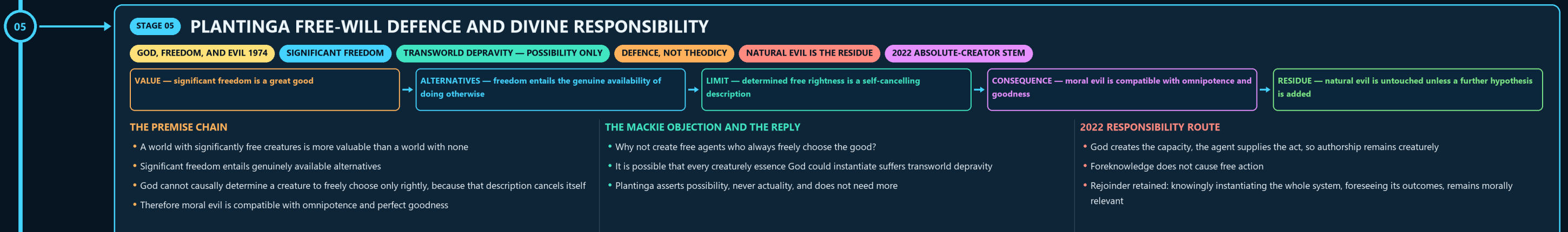
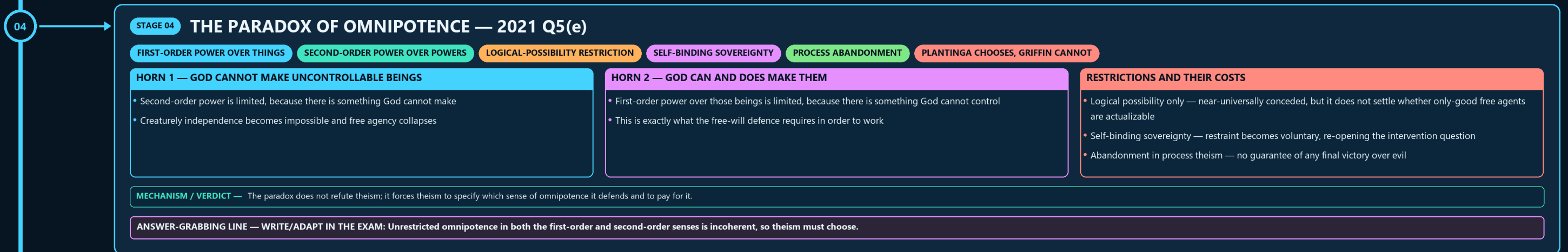
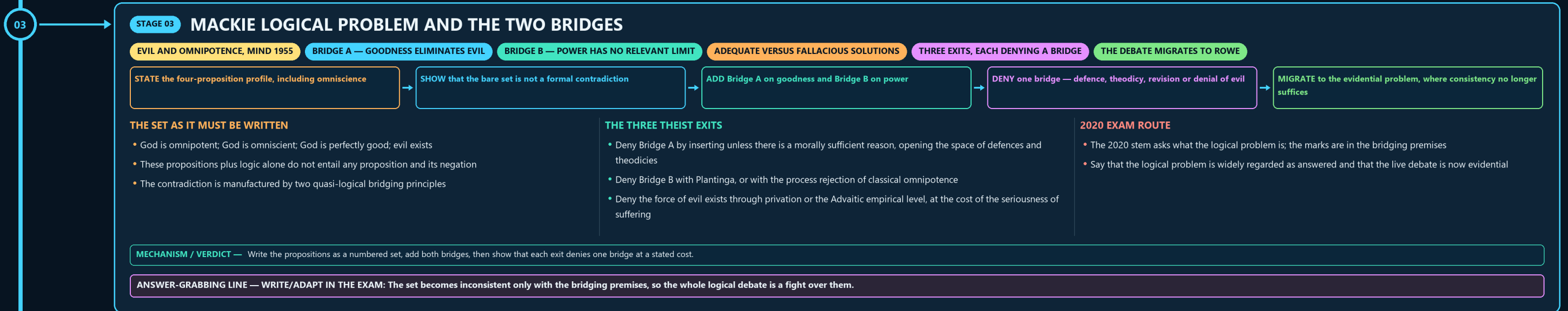
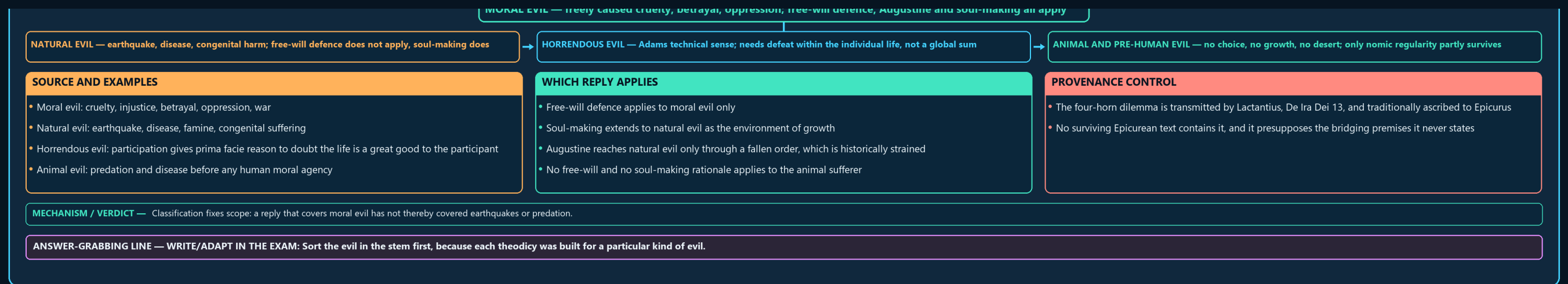
WHICH REPLY APPLIES

- Free-will defence applies to moral evil only
- Soul-making extends to natural evil as the environment of growth
- Augustine reaches natural evil only through a fallen order, which is historically strained
- No free-will and no soul-making rationale applies to the animal sufferer

PROVENANCE CONTROL

- The four-horn dilemma is transmitted by Lactantius, De Ira Dei 13, and traditionally ascribed to Epicurus
- No surviving Epicurean text contains it, and it presupposes the bridging premises it never states

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Classification fixes scope: a reply that covers moral evil has not thereby covered earthquakes or predation.



05

STAGE 05

PLANTINGA FREE-WILL DEFENCE AND DIVINE RESPONSIBILITY

GOD, FREEDOM, AND EVIL 1974

SIGNIFICANT FREEDOM

TRANSWORLD DEPRAVITY — POSSIBILITY ONLY

DEFENCE, NOT THEODICY

NATURAL EVIL IS THE RESIDUE

2022 ABSOLUTE-CREATOR STEM

VALUE — significant freedom is a great good

→

ALTERNATIVES — freedom entails the genuine availability of doing otherwise

→

LIMIT — determined free rightness is a self-cancelling description

→

CONSEQUENCE — moral evil is compatible with omnipotence and goodness

→

RESIDUE — natural evil is untouched unless a further hypothesis is added

THE PREMISE CHAIN

- A world with significantly free creatures is more valuable than a world with none
- Significant freedom entails genuinely available alternatives
- God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose only rightly, because that description cancels itself
- Therefore moral evil is compatible with omnipotence and perfect goodness

THE MACKIE OBJECTION AND THE REPLY

- Why not create free agents who always freely choose the good?
- It is possible that every creaturely essence God could instantiate suffers transworld depravity
- Plantinga asserts possibility, never actuality, and does not need more

2022 RESPONSIBILITY ROUTE

- God creates the capacity, the agent supplies the act, so authorship remains creaturely
- Foreknowledge does not cause free action
- Rejoinder retained: knowingly instantiating the whole system, foreseeing its outcomes, remains morally relevant

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The defence defeats the logical charge with bare possibility and leaves the quantity of suffering and all natural evil untouched.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A world of programmed beneficence lacks the moral authorship of a world containing genuinely responsible agents.

06

STAGE 06

AUGUSTINE — PRIVATION, SIN AND PUNISHMENT — 2023 Q8(a)

PRIVATION OF GOOD (PRIVATIO BONI)

DEFECTIVE WILL

PARASITIC ON A GOOD NATURE

THE FALL AND A DISORDERED ORDER

INHERITED GUILT VERSUS CONDITION

INNOCENT AND ANIMAL SUFFERING

THE METAPHYSICS, STATED FIRST

- Being insofar as it is being is good, and God creates beings rather than evil substances
- Corruption is parasitic and depends on a good nature to corrupt
- Moral fault is disordered willing, the will turning from a greater good to a lesser
- Rot is not a rival substance to wood but the loss of the wood proper integrity

THE PRINTED THESIS

- Moral evil is sin, the misuse of created freedom
- Natural evil is punishment through a fallen and disordered order
- Treat the printed sentence as the object of analysis, not as a certified verbatim translation

FOUR OBJECTIONS

- Innocent suffering fits a retributive reading poorly
- Animal and pre-human suffering involves no choice, no sin and no growth
- Privation is strained for intense positive pain, which does not feel like an absence
- Personal inherited guilt is far harder to defend than an inherited damaged condition, which still owes an explanation

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The account preserves divine goodness for moral evil while remaining incomplete for natural, innocent and animal suffering.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Calling blindness a privation does not call it unreal: it is a real lack in a subject that ought to possess sight.

07

STAGE 07

HICK IRENAEAN SOUL-MAKING AND THE ATTRIBUTION CHAIN

EVIL AND THE GOD OF LOVE 1966

IMAGE INTO LIKENESS — IRENAEUS

EPISTEMIC DISTANCE

LAW-GOVERNED WORLD

VALE OF SOUL-MAKING — KEATS 1819

PROPORTIONALITY AND ANIMALS

2nd century — Irenaeus supplies the image and likeness theology of growth

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spring 1819 — John Keats coins The vale of Soul-making in his journal-letter

→

1966 — Hick publishes Evil and the God of Love with epistemic distance

→

Coverage — moral and natural evil, unlike the free-will defence

→

Cost — proportionality, animal suffering and universal eschatological fulfilment

THE ARGUMENT

- Ready-made virtue is not achieved virtue
- Courage requires danger and compassion requires another need
- A world in which such virtues are possible must be law-governed and must therefore permit harm
- Humans are created immature at an epistemic distance so that faith is freely reached

THE TYPOLOGY

- Augustinian type: humanity created perfect, then a backward-looking Fall, with a retributive framing
- Irenaeian type: humanity created immature, then forward-looking growth toward likeness
- Soul-making covers natural evil as the environment of growth, which the free-will defence cannot

COSTS AND CONTROLS

- Proportionality: much suffering builds nothing, and the animal sufferer does not morally grow
- The reply is a universal eschatological fulfilment resting on contested afterlife commitments
- Keats coined the phrase, Irenaeus supplies the theology and Hick supplies the modern theodicy

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Development, not punishment, is the rationale, and its price is proportionality and a contested eschatology.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Courage requires danger and compassion requires need, so a world without suffering would lack the goods that make persons.

08

STAGE 08

ROWE EVIDENTIAL PROBLEM AND WYKSTRA CORNEA

GRATUITOUS EVIL

THE SUFFERING FAWN — EVIDENTIAL

THE NOSEUM INFERENCE

CORNEA 1984

REPRESENTATIVENESS THESES

MORAL SCEPTICISM IS THE PRICE

CASE — intense suffering with no discernible justifying good

→

STEP — from no reason seen to no reason exists

→

CONCLUSION — gratuitous evil makes a wholly good omnipotent God improbable

→

REPLY — CORNEA denies the epistemic access the step requires

→

PRICE — moral scepticism, ad hoc restriction and unfalsifiability

ROWE ARGUMENT, 1979

- There exist instances of intense suffering preventable without losing a greater good or permitting an equally bad evil
- A wholly good being would prevent any intense suffering it could, absent such a reason

SKEPTICAL THEISM, THE DEFENSIVE REPLY

- Wykstra CORNEA: an appearance of absence licenses a claim of absence only if the thing would likely be discernible
- Bergmann: our sample of goods, evils and their entailment relations is not representative of the total space

THREE STANDING COSTS

- Moral scepticism threatens the judgement that we ought to prevent an evil, and the duty to rescue
- Parity: the same scepticism undercuts divine promises unless restricted in an ad hoc way
- Bracketing: extended far enough, no evidence could ever count against theism

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The evidential problem is not solved by the defensive reply, and the price of the reply is moral scepticism, ad hoc restriction and unfalsifiability.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The evidential problem is not solved by the defensive reply, and the price of the reply is moral scepticism, ad hoc restriction and unfalsifiability.

STAGE 08

ROWE EVIDENTIAL PROBLEM AND WYKSTRA CORNEA

GRATUITOUS EVIL

THE SUFFERING FAWN — EVIDENTIAL

THE NOSEEUM INFERENCE

CORNEA 1984

REPRESENTATIVENESS THESES

MORAL SCEPTICISM IS THE PRICE

CASE — intense suffering with no discernible justifying good

STEP — from no reason seen to no reason exists

CONCLUSION — gratuitous evil makes a wholly good omnipotent God improbable

REPLY — CORNEA denies the epistemic access the step requires

PRICE — moral scepticism, ad hoc restriction and unfalsifiability

ROWE ARGUMENT, 1979

There exist instances of intense suffering preventable without losing a greater good or permitting an equally bad evil

A wholly good being would prevent any intense suffering it could, absent such a reason

The fawn removes free will, moral growth, desert and observer benefit from the case at once

SKEPTICAL THEISM, THE DEFENSIVE REPLY

Wykstra CORNEA: an appearance of absence licenses a claim of absence only if the thing would likely be discernible

Bergmann: our sample of goods, evils and their entailment relations is not representative of the total space

Alston grandmaster analogy and Wykstra infant analogy; proponents also include Howard-Snyder

THREE STANDING COSTS

Moral scepticism threatens the judgement that we ought to prevent an evil, and the duty to rescue

Parity: the same scepticism undercuts divine promises unless restricted in an ad hoc way

Bracketing: extended far enough, no evidence could ever count against theism

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Skeptical theism blocks the inference rather than naming a reason, and pays for it with a general loss of moral confidence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Rowe fawn is an evidential case, not a deductive contradiction, so consistency no longer discharges the burden.

STAGE 09

HORRENDOUS EVILS AND ANIMAL SUFFERING

BALANCING OFF VERSUS DEFEAT

GOODNESS TO PERSONS

CHISHOLM TERM — DEFEAT

COMPENSATION IS NOT DEFEAT

ONLY NOMIC REGULARITY SURVIVES

TIRYAK-YONI AND AHIMSA

REPLY TO ANIMAL SUFFERING	PRECISE CLAIM	STANDING COST
Neo-Cartesian, canvassed by Michael Murray 2008	Animals lack the higher-order awareness that makes pain matter morally	The premise is philosophically and empirically contested
Nomic regularity	A stable law-governed world is required to support any life at all	Explains the kind of world, not the amount of pain in it
Soul-making extended	Real danger is the only condition in which stewardship toward animals is possible	Uses animals instrumentally for human virtue
Eschatological fulfilment	Animal fulfilment or redemption in a final state, a minority line	Unverifiable and largely undeveloped
Fallen order	A cosmic fall distorts nature prior to human history	Historically and scientifically strained

ADAMS, HORRENDOUS EVILS 1999

A horrendous evil gives the participant, as perpetrator or victim, prima facie reason to doubt their life is a great good to them on the whole

Standard theodicies balance globally while an individual life may remain a net disaster

Only religion-specific resources such as divine identification and beatific intimacy can defeat within a life

ANIMAL AND PRE-HUMAN SUFFERING

The pain predates moral agency, so no free-will defence applies

The animal does not morally grow, so soul-making reaches it only instrumentally

Rowe fawn is the canonical evidential illustration

INDIAN PARITY AND ITS COST

Karma extends moral causation to animal births and answers distribution rather than personal worth

Jainism grounds non-injury in graded living selves; Buddhism extends compassion to sentient beings

The mechanism is unverifiable and must never be used to infer that present suffering is deserved

MECHANISM / VERDICT — These two cases are the standing residue of any twenty-mark answer, and naming them is itself a mark-earning move.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Global balancing is not personal defeat: a world can be good on the whole while a particular life is not.

STAGE 10

PROCESS THEODICY AND THE NON-CLASSICAL REPLY-SPACE — 2025 Q6(b)

DIPOLAR GOD

INITIAL AIM

PERSUASION BY METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY

FELLOW-SUFFERER WHO UNDERSTANDS

CLASSICAL OMNIPOTENCE IS INCOHERENT

SOVEREIGNTY IS THE PRICE

THE SIX TENETS, NUMBERED

Creativity, not God, is the ultimate, and actual entities are self-creative occasions

God is dipolar: the primordial nature supplies each occasion its initial aim, the consequent nature receives what the world becomes

Power is intrinsically distributed, because to be actual is to have some self-determination

Divine power is therefore persuasive by metaphysical necessity, not by self-limitation

Evil is the deviation of finite occasions from the divine lure, so God is not culpable

God is the fellow-sufferer who understands: solidarity rather than detachment

NAME THE LAYER YOU ARE USING

Whitehead, Process and Reality 1929: dipolarity, initial aim, consequent nature, the fellow-sufferer

Hartshorne, The Divine Relativity 1948 and Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes 1984: classical omnipotence is incoherent

Griffin, God, Power, and Evil 1976 and Evil Revisited 1991: persuasion is a metaphysical necessity, not a chosen restraint

Cobb, A Christian Natural Theology: the theological systematisation

THE SURROUNDING REPLY-SPACE, EACH PRICED

Greater-good and stable order explain the kind of world, not the amount or distribution of suffering

Leibnizian best world of 1710 may have no unique optimum and can neglect goodness to particular persons

Eschatological fulfilment offers compensation, which is not automatically justification

Divine mystery is unfalsifiable without an access principle; protest settles no logical or evidential point

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Griffin God cannot coerce while Plantinga God chooses not to intervene, and that modal difference separates theodicy from defence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Process theodicy purchases the innocence of God at the price of the sovereignty of God, and the trade must be stated.

STAGE 11

INDIAN RESPONSES AND THE INDIA-WEST PARITY BENCH

KARMA-SAMSARA IS SELF-OPERATING

KARMADHYAKSA — GOD AS JUDGE

BEGINNINGLESS SERIES

VYAVAHARIKA AND PARAMARTHIKA

NO DEFENDANT AT ALL

VICTIM-BLAMING CONTROL

- Evil is the deviation of finite occasions from the divine lure, so God is not culpable
- God is the fellow-sufferer who understands: solidarity rather than detachment

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Griffin God cannot coerce while Plantinga God chooses not to intervene, and that modal difference separates theodicy from defence.

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11

STAGE 11

INDIAN RESPONSES AND THE INDIA-WEST PARITY BENCH

KARMA-SAMSARA IS SELF-OPERATINGKARMADHYAKSA — GOD AS JUDGEBEGINNINGLESS SERIESVYAVAHARIKA AND PARAMARTHIKANNO DEFENDANT AT ALLVICTIM-BLAMING CONTROL

ORIGINATION — ignorance, inflow of karmic matter and craving replace the question of divine permission

ALLOCATION — deeds ripen across lives, so distribution is explained without charging a creator

ADMINISTRATION — Nyaya and Ramanuja retain God as a just dispenser of karmic fruit

DISSOLUTION — Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa need no divine distributor at all

THE SCHOOLS DIFFER

- Non-theistic Buddhist, Jain and Mimamsa accounts require no divine distributor, so there is no defendant
- Nyaya and theistic Vedanta assign God a just administrative role as karma-superintendent, a judge rather than an arbitrary cause
- Advaita treats evil as real at the empirical level and sublated at the ultimate level, at the risk of minimising suffering

WHAT THE PARITY BENCH SHOWS

- Why this person: karma across lives answers what Western theodicy answers weakly
- Why so much: beginningless samsara denies the frame rather than justifying a quantity
- What defeats evil for the sufferer: defeat within the life versus exit from the life-series through liberation

NON-NEGOTIABLE MORAL CONTROLS

- Beginninglessness blocks one regress question and verifies nothing about any claimed past-life cause
- The inference from this person suffers to this person deserves it is unavailable to ordinary observers
- Karma does not cancel present duties of compassion, protection and relief

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The distributional gain is real and school-specific, and it is purchased with an unverifiable trans-life mechanism.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: India answers a different question: not why evil is permitted, but why this person suffers, and it can drop the defendant.

12

STAGE 12

RELIGION-FOUNDING EVIL, CONCEPT-DEPENDENCE AND THE GRADED VERDICT

PROFANE IS THE ORDINARY, NOT THE WICKEDPREDICAMENT TO BOUNDARY TO SOTERIOLOGYDURKHEIM, OTTO, ELIADECONCEPT-DEPENDENCE IS NOT A SOLUTIONEVERY REPLY IS PRICEDNEVER END DEVOTIONALLY

FUNCTIONAL READING — evil and the profane supply the predicament and the boundary

CATEGORY DISCIPLINE — evil, profane, impure and demonic are four distinct categories

VARY THE GOD-CONCEPT — classical, finite, impersonal, non-creator

PRICE EACH DISSOLUTION — sovereignty, personality, providence

GRADE — coverage, preserved attribute, cost and residue, then a qualified conclusion

2019 OWNER-MODULE — EVIL AND THE PROFANE

- Durkheim 1912: all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of things into sacred and profane, and the definition is deliberately God-free
- Otto 1917 supplies the object-side numinous; Eliade 1957 supplies hierophany, sacred space around a world-axis and recoverable sacred time
- Founding sequence: predicament, then boundary, then institution, then soteriology
- Buddhism First Noble Truth is the clearest world case; India founding defect is more often ignorance or bondage than moral evil

2024 CONCEPT-DEPENDENCE

- Classical theism carries the full force of all three burdens
- A finite or process God dissolves the logical charge and surrenders sovereignty
- An impersonal Absolute relocates evil to the empirical level and risks minimising suffering
- Removing the creator leaves no defendant and gives up providence and a cosmic guarantor of justice

THE ANSWER ROUTE AND VERDICT LADDER

- Name the version, write the set with its bridges, reconstruct the reply as premises, object and reply, compare, then grade
- Bands: ten marks about 150 words, fifteen marks about 240 to 260, twenty marks about 340 to 360
- Top band adds defeat versus balancing off, or CORNEA, or the animal gap, and states what the theist has given up
- A theodicy is not refuted by its cost but is measured by it, so the final task is to state the price

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Evil and the profane found religion structurally rather than doctrinally, and they found religion rather than theism.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The problem of evil is a stress-test of a particular God-concept, not of religion as such.

E

EXTRA

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

MODAL AND FEASIBLE WORLDSDRAPER CUMULATIVE EVIDENCEPROPORTIONALITY TESTINGESSAY LABORATORY PROMPTSPASTORAL RESTRAINT

SECOND-ORDER DEBATES

- Whether a positive theodicy can be combined consistently with global scepticism about divine reasons
- Whether defeat within the life of a sufferer is still a general theodicy at all
- Grounding objections to counterfactuals of freedom in feasible-world accounts

DEPLOYMENT RULE

- Use at most one refinement in a fifteen-marker and at most two in a twenty-marker
- Never use an advanced move to repair a missing core doctrine, thinker or distinction

OPTIONAL STATUS — This enrichment is unnecessary for a competent core answer and must never replace the core spine.